

Complex Tense Forms

Meaning of Tense

Tense refers to the form of a verb that shows the time an action happens.

There are three main tenses in English:

Present Tense – action happening now

Past Tense – action that has already happened

Future Tense – action that will happen later

Complex tense forms are tenses that use more than one verb (helping verbs + main verb).

Types of Complex Tense Forms

1. Present Continuous Tense

Structure

Subject + am/is/are + verb + ing

Uses

Actions happening now

Temporary actions

Examples

I am reading a book.

She is cooking.

They are playing football.

2. Past Continuous Tense

Structure

Subject + was/were + verb + ing

Uses

Action that was going on in the past

Interrupted past action



Examples

I was sleeping when you called.

They were dancing yesterday.

She was writing a letter.

3. Future Continuous Tense

Structure

Subject + will be + verb + ing

Uses

Action that will be happening in the future

Examples

I will be travelling tomorrow.

She will be studying tonight.

They will be playing by noon.

Perfect Tenses

Perfect tenses show completed actions.

4. Present Perfect Tense

Structure

Subject + has/have + past participle

Uses

Action completed recently

Experience

Examples

I have eaten.

She has finished her work.

They have travelled to Lagos.



5. Past Perfect Tense

Structure

Subject + had + past participle

Uses

Action completed before another past action

Examples

He had left before I arrived.

They had eaten before the meeting started.

She had written the test earlier.

6. Future Perfect Tense

Structure

Subject + will have + past participle

Uses

Action that will be completed before a future time

Examples

I will have finished the work by Friday.

She will have arrived before noon.

They will have completed the project soon.

Perfect Continuous Tenses

These tenses show actions that continue over a period of time.

7. Present Perfect Continuous Tense

Structure

Subject + has/have been + verb + ing

Uses

Action that started in the past and is still continuing



Examples

I have been reading for two hours.

She has been singing since morning.

They have been working all day.

8. Past Perfect Continuous Tense

Structure

Subject + had been + verb + ing

Uses

Continuous action before another past action

Examples

He had been sleeping before the noise started.

They had been waiting for hours.

She had been teaching before she retired.

9. Future Perfect Continuous Tense

Structure

Subject + will have been + verb + ing

Uses

Continuous action that will continue up to a point in the future

Examples

By next year, I will have been working here for five years.

She will have been studying for hours by then.

They will have been travelling all day.

Summary Table

Tense

Structure



Example

Present Continuous

am/is/are + ing

She is singing

Past Continuous

was/were + ing

They were dancing

Future Continuous

will be + ing

I will be reading

Present Perfect

has/have + past participle

He has gone

Past Perfect

had + past participle

She had left

Future Perfect

will have + past participle

They will have finished

Present Perfect Continuous

has/have been + ing

I have been reading

Past Perfect Continuous

had been + ing

He had been working



Future Perfect Continuous

will have been + ing

She will have been teaching

Important Notes

Helping verbs are important in complex tense forms.

The main verb may appear as:

Present participle (-ing)

Past participle (eaten, gone, written)

Time expressions often help identify tense:

now, yesterday, since, for, tomorrow, by next week

Exercise

Change the verbs in brackets to the correct complex tense form.

She _____ (read) for two hours.

They _____ (finish) the work before noon.

I _____ (wait) when he arrived.

We _____ (travel) tomorrow morning.

He _____ (study) since morning.

Answers

has been reading

will have finished

was waiting

will be travelling

has been studying

